General rule – components and focus · "Spells" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

A spell may require **components**: **Verbal (V)**, **Somatic (S)** and **Material (M)**. If you can't provide them, you can't cast the spell.

Material components with no cost can be replaced by a **focus** (Arcane Focus, Holy Symbol, Druidic Focus) or a component pouch. If a cost is listed, you need the exact materials.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **V**: speak aloud.
2. **S**: a free hand for gestures.
3. **M**: materials or a focus.
4. Materials with a cost: must be provided; consumed only if stated.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 clarifies you can use the hand holding the focus or a Material component for gestures.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The rule doesn't say what happens with hands full (weapon and shield). Fix: draw or stow, or use the hand holding the focus.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the spell's gestures and words so the component is visible at the table.

Step 1 – Read the components:

V, S, M are noted in the spell header.

Step 2 – Check V:

You must be able to speak (no Silence, no gag).

Step 3 – Check S:

A free hand, or the hand holding the focus / a Material component.

Step 4 – Check M:

Focus or pouch for no-cost materials; exact materials otherwise.

Step 5 – Cast:

If components are met, the spell is cast. Consumed materials vanish.

Example: Elora holds a sword and a focus. She can use the focus hand for gestures (S) and the focus for a no-cost M component.

Component	Rule
Verbal (V)	Spoken words; impossible in a Silence area.
Somatic (S)	Gestures with a free hand (or the focus hand).
Material (M)	Materials or a focus; cost required if listed; consumed if stated.

Common cases

Situation	What to know
Weapon and shield in hand	A focus can be held in the free hand; otherwise stow or drop an item.
Silence or gag	Can't cast a spell with a Verbal component.
Bound hands	Can't cast a spell with a Somatic component.
Materials with a cost	Provide exactly the listed materials, consumed if stated.
Materials with no cost	A focus or a component pouch is enough.

⚠ Common questions:

Must I speak to cast?

Yes if V is required.

Can I cast with hands full?

S: a free hand (or the focus hand) is needed.

Does a focus replace everything?

Only no-cost materials.

Are costly materials consumed?

Only if the spell says so.

Can I cast under Silence?

Not if V is required.

Can the focus be a weapon?

Yes if the class says so (Holy Symbol on a shield, for example).

Does a component pouch replace it?

Yes for no-cost materials.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Hands full

Two weapons in hand: **Option**: a hand can stow a weapon as an object interaction.

Gag

Can I cast gagged? **Option**: no for V.

Stolen focus

Without a focus, no M spells.
Option: allow improvised materials.

Costly components

Tracking cost in coins. **Option**: keep it.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Focus

It replaces no-cost materials, not those with a price.

Free hand

The hand holding the focus counts as free for S.

Verbal

Silence prevents any V spell.

Consumed

Only materials marked as consumed vanish.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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